water is a fundamental human right, she set out how wastage, pollution, and overconsumption meant that the water cycle—the constant exchange of water between Earth's surface and the atmosphere—could not be relied upon to provide water forever. She said that shortage of water was already a crisis in the developing world, where in particular women and children who collect water bear the brunt—and unless drastic action is taken, the rest of the world will be affected too.

In 2024, it was estimated that 4 billion people around the world lack safe drinking water. This is double that estimated in 2020. Although 70 percent of Earth's surface is covered by water, almost all of it is saline ocean water. Only 0.014 percent of the planet's water is both fresh and easily accessible. It is obtained mostly from rivers, lakes, and underground aquifers (rock containing groundwater). People use water to drink, wash, irrigate crops, and run industry, and since all plants and terrestrial animals require freshwater to live, all are affected by the water crisis.